The Golden Years Love Story

How the Stars Found Love, Friendship and Company After 65, and How You Can Too

From the Behind the Fame YouTube channel

Please read this first

This book is for information and enjoyment. It is not legal, financial, medical or psychological advice. Before you marry, move in with someone, change a will, or sign anything late in life, talk to a lawyer and, if money is involved, a financial professional. If you are grieving and it is not lifting, or if you ever feel you do not want to go on, call or text 988, any hour, and tell someone. The stories here come from the stars' own memoirs, interviews and public records. Where accounts differ, we say so.

Welcome

Dick Van Dyke married the love of his life at eighty-six.

Joan Collins married hers at sixty-eight, and when people pointed out that he was thirty-two years younger, she said, “If he dies, he dies.”

Carol Burnett married at sixty-eight too, a man she met in an orchestra pit, and has spent twenty-four years with him.

Betty White was widowed at fifty-nine, never remarried, and lived forty more years so full of friends, work and laughter that nobody ever thought to call her alone.

Dolly Parton was married to the same man for fifty-eight years, and buried him in the spring of 2025, and is still, at eighty, finding a way through.

And Diane Keaton never married at all, by choice, and was, by every account including her own, one of the happiest women in Hollywood.

Every week on our channel we open the files on the private lives of the stars, and nothing brings more of you to the comments than love: the marriages that lasted, the ones that broke, the second chances, the losses. But under those comments there is almost always a quieter question. *What about me?*

What about me, widowed at seventy-one, when everyone assumes that part of my life is over? What about me, divorced at sixty-six, who hasn't been on a date since Nixon? What about me, married forty years to a man who is now home all day and driving me up the wall? What about me, whose friends are dying, whose children live three states away, who has not been hugged in a month?

This book is the answer, and the stars are the proof.

It is in five parts. **The Second Chance**: how the stars who found love late actually did it, and the practical guide to dating after sixty-five, from the first phone call to the prenup. **The Long Love**: what the fifty-year marriages have in common, and how to survive retirement, illness and the quiet years together. **After Loss**: what the stars did

in the first year of widowhood, and what the research says protects you. **Friends and Family**: the truth about the Golden Girls, how to make a friend at seventy, and how to be the grandmother they call. And **Yourself**: the stars who lived alone and loved it, and how to build a life that is full whether or not anyone else is in it.

Every chapter ends with three things you can do this week. Some are as small as a phone call. All of them are things a star in this book actually did.

Love after sixty-five is not a consolation prize. Ask Dick Van Dyke.

The Behind the Fame team

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Part One: The Second Chance

Chapter 1. Dick Van Dyke: Married at 86

In 2006, at an awards dinner in Los Angeles, an eighty-year-old Dick Van Dyke went looking for someone to fix his makeup and found a thirty-four-year-old makeup artist named Arlene Silver. They talked. He thought she was funny. She thought he was kind. He asked if she would like to work with him on a few projects. She said yes.

Nothing happened for years. Then, slowly, something did.

By the time they married, in February 2012, he was eighty-six and she was forty. He had been a widower for three years, after the death of Michelle Triola, the woman he had lived with for thirty-five years. Before that, he had been married for thirty-six years to Margie Willett, the

mother of his four children. He was, by any measure, a man at the end of a long romantic life, not the beginning of one.

The newspapers did the math and had a field day. Forty-six years. His children were older than his bride. The internet assumed the worst.

What did Dick Van Dyke say? He said, cheerfully, that he had no idea why she married him and he was not going to question it. He said that his children had met her, spent time with her, and liked her. He said that she made him laugh every single day. And he said something that every person over sixty-five who is thinking about love should hear: “I think people my age are sometimes afraid to start over. I wasn’t. What was I waiting for?”

Then he went and lived another fourteen years, and counting.

Here is what the marriage looks like from the inside, by their own accounts. They sing together; she is in his barbershop group. They go to the gym together three mornings a week, which is why he is still walking. She

films him dancing in the kitchen. They have made a short film together. She has said that she never thinks about the age difference except when a reporter brings it up. He has said that she is the reason he gets up in the morning, and that he thinks he will live to a hundred because of her. He turned a hundred in December 2025. He was right.

What this means for you

Dick Van Dyke's story is the extreme case, which is why it is useful. If a man of eighty-six can start over, so can a woman of seventy. Here is what his story actually teaches, apart from the headline.

Late love usually begins as friendship. They worked together for years before anything else. Older couples who last almost always describe the same thing: a slow start, built on company and laughter, long before romance. You are not looking for a date. You are looking for someone you like to talk to. The rest follows or it doesn't.

Your children will have opinions. Listen, then decide. Van Dyke's children met Arlene early, often, and on their own terms, and he did not ask their permission but he did

want their blessing. Adult children worry about two things: that you will be hurt, and, quietly, about money. Both are fair. Introduce the person early. Be open about your finances and your will. And remember that your children do not get a vote on your happiness, only a voice.

Age gaps are nobody's business but yours, with one caution. A large gap is fine if you have asked yourself honestly why this person is with you, and if your money is protected. More on that in Chapter 4 and at the back of the book.

The things that keep you alive are the things you do together. The gym three mornings a week. The singing. The laughing. Married older adults live longer than single ones, and the research is clear on why: someone to notice when you are unwell, someone to eat with, someone to get you out of the chair. You do not need a spouse for that. You need a person. But a spouse counts.

"What was I waiting for?" Most women over sixty-five who say they are done with love have not decided that.

They have assumed it. Van Dyke's question is the one to ask.

Three things to do this week

1. **Answer the question honestly.** On paper: "Would I like someone in my life again? Yes, no, or not sure." There is no wrong answer. But know yours.
2. **Name the fear.** If the answer is yes but you have done nothing, write down what stops you: your children, your body, your money, your late husband, looking foolish. Every one of those has a chapter in this book.
3. **Say yes to one invitation** you would normally decline, from anyone, for any reason. Dick Van Dyke went to an awards dinner he did not much feel like attending.

Chapter 2. Joan Collins: “If he dies, he dies”

By the time Joan Collins married for the fifth time, she had been divorced four times, widowed none, and written off by the tabloids as a woman who could not keep a husband.

She was sixty-eight. The groom, Percy Gibson, was a theater manager she had met while touring a play in San Francisco. He was thirty-six. A reporter asked her, with the usual smirk, whether she was worried about the age difference, given that he might outlive her by decades.

“If he dies,” she said, “he dies.”

It was a joke, and it was also a philosophy. Joan Collins had spent four marriages, by her own account, trying to be what a husband wanted. Her first husband was abusive. Her fourth, a Swedish singer eighteen years her junior, she described as a disaster she should have seen coming. She had been, she said, “a terrible picker.” By sixty-eight she had stopped picking for a husband and started picking for herself: someone kind, someone funny, someone who liked

her exactly as she was, including the age, the career, the children, the grandchildren, and the opinions.

Percy Gibson, by her description, is the first man who never once asked her to be less. They have been married since 2002. She still works constantly; he manages her career. They travel between London, Los Angeles and the south of France. In interviews she says, without embarrassment, that it is the happiest she has ever been, and that she wishes she had understood at thirty what she understood at sixty-eight.

What did she understand? She has put it several ways over the years, and it comes down to this: by the time you are sixty-five, you know who you are. You know what you will and will not tolerate. You have your own money, your own friends, your own house and your own life. You are not auditioning. You are choosing. And a woman who is choosing, rather than hoping to be chosen, makes very different decisions.

She has one more piece of advice, delivered to a magazine when she was eighty: “Never, ever, settle. Not at twenty,

and certainly not at seventy. At seventy, you don’t have time to settle.”

What this means for you

Joan Collins is talking about the single biggest advantage a woman over sixty-five has in love, and almost nobody tells her she has it.

You are choosing now, not being chosen. The young date to find out who they are. You already know. That means you can skip years of pretending. The women who find good late love describe the same thing: they stopped trying to be appealing and started being honest from the first conversation. About what they want, about their health, about their children, about their money, about their late husband. The right person is relieved. The wrong one leaves early, which saves time.

“Never settle” has a practical meaning after 65. It means: do not accept rudeness, controlling behavior, drinking, or someone who is unkind to your family because you are afraid there will be no one else. There will be someone else, or there will be a good life alone, and

both are better than a bad companion. Women over sixty-five are, sadly, the most common targets of controlling and financially abusive late relationships, precisely because they fear being alone. Fear is the thing to get rid of first.

The list. Write down the five things a companion must have and the five things you will not accept. Joan's "must" list, by her own account, was short: kind, funny, honest, likes my life. Her "never" list came from four marriages: no drinkers, no liars, no one who needs me to be smaller. Yours will be different. Write it before you meet anyone, not after.

Your own life is the attraction. Collins kept working, kept her friends, kept her houses. A woman with a full life is not looking for someone to fill it; she is looking for someone to share it. That is a very different and far more attractive proposition, at any age.

Three things to do this week

1. **Write the two lists.** Five things a companion must have. Five things you will never accept again.

Keep it in a drawer.

2. **Say one true thing out loud.** To a friend, your daughter, or the mirror: what you actually want for the next ten years of your life. Not what is sensible. What you want.
3. **Do one thing for your own life** that has nothing to do with anyone else: a class, a trip, a haircut you have wanted for years. Joan would.

Chapter 3. Carol Burnett: A man in the orchestra pit

In the 1990s Carol Burnett was touring a musical called *Moon Over Buffalo*, and in the orchestra pit, playing the drums, was a man named Brian Miller.

She noticed him. He noticed her. Nothing happened, because she was in her sixties, twice divorced, and had decided, with the clarity of a woman who had been burned, that she was done with all that. Her second marriage, to the producer Joe Hamilton, had lasted twenty

years and given her three daughters and the most famous variety show in television history, and had ended, like her first, in a divorce that she took hard. She had been single for the better part of twenty years. She was, she said, content.

Brian Miller kept showing up. He was a musician, not a star, and twenty-three years younger. He was, by her description, funny, patient, and completely uninterested in her fame. They became friends. And slowly, somewhere in her late sixties, the friendship became something else.

They married in November 2001. She was sixty-eight.

Two months later, her oldest daughter, Carrie Hamilton, died of cancer at thirty-eight.

Carol Burnett has said that she does not know how she would have survived that year without him. “He held me up,” she said. There were no cameras, no interviews, no grand gestures. There was a man who got up every morning and made the coffee and sat with her while she wept and did not try to fix it. That, she said later, was when she understood what she had married.

They have been together more than twenty-four years. She is ninety-three. In 2020, at eighty-seven, she and Brian petitioned a court for guardianship of her teenage grandson, Dylan, because his mother, Carol's daughter Erin, was struggling with addiction. A woman of eighty-seven became, in effect, a mother again, and her husband of nineteen years became a father, and neither of them hesitated.

Asked once what she would tell a woman her age who thought love was behind her, she laughed her famous laugh and said: "Honey, I thought so too."

What this means for you

Carol Burnett's story holds two lessons that the happy headlines usually leave out.

The right person is revealed by the hard year, not the honeymoon. Many late marriages begin in good health and sunshine. All of them will eventually meet illness, loss, a sick child or grandchild, a fall. Before you commit to anyone late in life, you will want to have seen how they behave when something goes wrong, for you or for them.

How do they treat a waiter, a sick friend, their own mother? Do they show up, or do they disappear? Burnett had seen Brian Miller be patient and kind for years before she married him. Two months later she needed every ounce of it.

Late love means late family. A new husband at sixty-eight is a new grandfather at seventy, and possibly, as in Carol's case, a new father to a child in trouble. The person you choose will be in your children's and grandchildren's lives. Choose someone who wants that, and tell your family early, honestly, so there are no surprises in a hospital corridor.

"Content" is not the same as "finished." Burnett had built a good single life and would have been fine without Brian Miller. That is precisely why the marriage worked: she was not looking to be rescued. If you are content alone, you are in the best possible position to love someone, because you can afford to be choosy.

The orchestra pit. He was not where she would have looked. He was younger, less famous, in a different world.

The women who find good late love almost all say the same thing: he was not the type. Widen the net.

Three things to do this week

1. **Think of someone who has already shown up for you** in a hard moment, whoever they are, and tell them, in a call or a note, that you noticed.
2. **Look where you would not look.** Make a list of three places you go every week where you have never once started a conversation with a stranger. Next week, start one.
3. **Tell one family member** how you really feel about the possibility of someone new, so that if someone appears, it is not a surprise.

Chapter 4. Jane Fonda: Dating after 65, honestly

In 2015, Jane Fonda, then seventy-seven, began starring in a television comedy called *Grace and Frankie*, about two

women in their seventies whose husbands leave them for each other. The show ran for seven seasons and became, by accident, the most honest guide to late life that American television had ever produced: dating, sex, loneliness, vibrators, strokes, funerals, friendship, and the particular indignity of being treated as invisible in a hardware store.

Jane Fonda did not have to act much. She had been married three times, to a French film director, a radical politician and a billionaire, and divorced three times. In her seventies she dated a record producer named Richard Perry for eight years and then ended it, saying, “I’ve closed up shop down there.” She has been, by her own cheerful admission, more open about sex in her seventies and eighties than any woman of her generation, and she has said that the best sex of her life happened after seventy, because she finally knew what she wanted and was not afraid to say it.

She has also said, at eighty-five, that she is done with romance and happier for it, that she prefers her friends, especially Lily Tomlin, and that she will not date again

because “I don’t want to take care of anybody.” Both things are true. That is the point of this chapter.

Here is what she has learned, in her own words from interviews and her book *Prime Time*, and what the research adds.

The honest guide to dating after 65

Where people actually meet. Not in bars. Older couples who meet after sixty-five most often meet through friends, through activities (classes, church, volunteering, clubs), through old acquaintances who resurface after a loss, and, more and more, online. About one in five people over sixty-five who are single now use a dating site or app. The ones built for older adults are OurTime, SilverSingles and SeniorMatch; the general ones with large numbers of people over sixty are Match and eHarmony. A profile with a recent, honest photograph and three true sentences about your life does better than anything clever.

The first contact is a phone call, not a dinner. Talk on the telephone first, for twenty minutes. You will learn more than in three dinners. If the voice is kind and the

conversation easy, meet for coffee, in daylight, in public, for an hour, with your own transportation. Tell a friend where you are. That is not paranoia; it is what every safety expert recommends for every age.

Say the true things early. Your health. Your children. Your late husband, if you are widowed, and that you will always love him. Your money, in general terms: that you have your own and intend to keep it that way. Your boundaries. The right person hears all this with relief.

The rules that protect you. Older women are the chief targets of romance scams, and the losses are enormous: hundreds of millions of dollars a year reported, and far more not reported out of shame. The rules are simple and absolute. Never send money, gift cards, or bank details to anyone you have not met in person many times, no matter the story: a stranded relative, a medical emergency, a customs fee, an investment. Never let anyone rush you to move the conversation off the dating site to text or email. Be suspicious of anyone who falls in love within days, who cannot ever meet in person or on video, who is "working overseas," or whose photographs look like a

model. If something feels wrong, it is. Call the AARP Fraud Watch helpline at 877-908-3360, which is free, and they will tell you in two minutes whether what you are describing is a known scam.

Sex after 65. Fonda's honesty is worth copying. Most women over sixty-five are still interested, many more than they admit, and the ones who are not are not broken. What changes: vaginal dryness after menopause, which a doctor can treat easily with low-dose estrogen cream, and which makes the difference between pain and pleasure; slower arousal, in both of you, which is a reason to take time; and the need, which surprises people, for protection. Sexually transmitted infections in people over sixty-five have risen sharply, because nobody thinks to ask. Ask. And talk to your doctor before anything; it is their job and they have heard it all.

Being done is also an answer. Fonda's "I don't want to take care of anybody" is a complete sentence. Many women who have nursed a husband through a long illness have no wish to do it again, and a man in his seventies is, statistically, a man who will need care. Choosing company

without marriage, or friendship without romance, or your own bed and your own remote control, is not failure. It is a choice, and this book honors it. Part Five is for you.

Three things to do this week

1. **Tell one friend you are open to meeting someone.** Most late introductions come through friends who did not know you were interested.
2. **If you are curious about online dating,** have a grandchild or a librarian sit with you for half an hour and set up a profile on one site, with a recent photograph. You can delete it anytime.
3. **Write the two safety rules on a card** and put it by the telephone: *I never send money to anyone I haven't met. I always meet in public, in daylight, with my own car.*

Part Two: The Long Love

Chapter 5. Dolly and Carl: Fifty-eight years

On her first day in Nashville, in 1964, eighteen-year-old Dolly Parton walked out of a laundromat and a man in a pickup truck drove by and waved. His name was Carl Dean. He was twenty-one, and he laid asphalt for a living. He has said, in one of the perhaps three sentences he ever gave to the press, that his first thought was that he was going to marry that girl.

They married two years later, on May 30, 1966, in a small church in Georgia, because her record label had told her not to get married and she did not want to argue with them in Tennessee. Her mother was the only guest.

For the next fifty-eight years, Carl Dean did not go to her concerts. He did not walk red carpets. He did not give

interviews, appear in photographs, or, as far as anyone can tell, care at all that his wife had become one of the most famous people on earth. He ran his paving business, and then retired, and mowed the lawn, and fixed things, and waited for her to come home.

The tabloids spent decades insisting the marriage was a sham, that he did not exist, that she was secretly with her best friend, that they lived apart. Dolly laughed at all of it and said the same thing every time: “He’s the only man I ever loved. He’s a good man, and he loves me for me.”

So what was the secret of fifty-eight years? She has been asked ten thousand times, and her answers, put together, make a short and practical list.

They were apart a lot. She has said, more than once and only half joking, that the secret to a long marriage is to “stay gone.” She was on the road for months. He was at home. When she came back, they were glad to see each other. “You can’t get sick of somebody you don’t see.”

They had separate lives and one home. He had his friends, his tractor, his quiet. She had her career, her band,

her Dollywood. They did not try to share everything. They shared a house, a bed, a sense of humor, and a set of memories that went back to a laundromat.

They laughed. Every account of the two of them, from the few people who saw them together, describes the same thing: he teased her, she teased back, and they laughed. She has said that she never married a man who could not make her laugh, and that she only married one man.

She never made him be someone else. He did not want to be in her world, and she did not drag him into it. She has said that if she had made him come to the shows and the parties, the marriage would have been over in five years.

They kept a little romance. Picnics in the truck, by her account. Drives to nowhere. A birthday song written just for him. Small things, kept up for six decades.

Carl Dean died on March 3, 2025, at eighty-two. Dolly released a song for him within days. She was seventy-nine.

What this means for you

The research on marriages that last fifty years looks a great deal like Dolly's list, and it has a few things to add.

Long marriages are not conflict-free. They are repair-rich. Couples who last argue about as much as couples who split. The difference is that they repair quickly: a joke, a touch, an apology, going to bed friends. Dolly's humor is a repair tool.

Space is not distance. Couples who keep separate friends, interests and even separate rooms for hobbies report more satisfaction, not less. This matters enormously in retirement, which the next chapter covers.

Acceptance beats improvement. Trying to change a spouse of forty years is the most reliable way to make both of you miserable. Dolly never tried to make Carl like the spotlight. The research calls it "accepting influence" and "positive sentiment override," which means, in plain words, deciding to see the good.

The marriage needs its own small rituals. A Friday supper. A Sunday drive. A song. Couples who keep one or two rituals through the decades describe feeling “still married,” not just still together.

Three things to do this week

1. **If you are married, go somewhere for an hour, alone, that is yours.** Then come home and see if he is glad to see you.
2. **Say the one thing you have been trying to change in him, out loud, and then let it go** for seven days. See what happens to the house.
3. **Revive one ritual** that you used to have and dropped: the Friday supper, the drive, the song. Just once this week.

Chapter 6. Paul and Joanne, Kirk and Anne: Fifty years, with letters, and surviving retirement together

When reporters asked Paul Newman why he had never strayed from Joanne Woodward in fifty years of marriage, when he could have had any woman in Hollywood, he gave an answer that has been printed on more kitchen magnets than any line he ever said in a movie.

“Why go out for hamburger when you have steak at home?”

Joanne Woodward, for the record, hated the line. She thought it made her sound like a cut of meat. But she did not dispute the point. They married in 1958 and were married until his death in 2008. They made a dozen films together, raised three daughters and his three children from a first marriage, built a house in Connecticut, and, by the account of their daughters, argued, laughed, drank, cooked, and read in the same room for half a century. When Joanne developed Alzheimer’s disease in her late

seventies, Paul, already dying of cancer, cared for her until he could not.

What they did that most couples do not: they worked together, deliberately, long after they could have afforded not to. They directed each other. They ran a camp for sick children together. They had a project, always, that was theirs.

Kirk and Anne Douglas lasted even longer: sixty-five years, from 1954 until his death in 2020 at a hundred and three. And they left something behind that very few couples do. In 2017 they published a book of the letters they had written each other across six decades, including the years when he was, by his own admission, unfaithful, and the years after his stroke when he could barely speak. The letters are not sentimental. They are funny, furious, practical, and full of the ordinary business of a long life: money, children, houses, illness, jealousy, forgiveness. What comes through is that they never stopped writing. Even in the same house. Even after sixty years.

Anne Douglas said, at ninety-eight, that the secret was simple: “I never stopped being interested in him, and he never stopped trying to interest me.” She also said, dryly, that it helped that he was away filming a great deal of the time. Dolly would understand.

What this means for you: the retirement problem

Here is the part of the long marriage that nobody warns you about. For forty years, he went to work and you had the house, or you both went to work and had the evenings. Then he retires. And he is home. All day. Every day. In your kitchen, rearranging your drawers, following you from room to room, asking what’s for lunch.

Marriage counselors have a name for it: “retired husband syndrome,” and it is real. The divorce rate for couples over sixty-five has doubled in the last thirty years, and retirement is one of the biggest triggers. Here is what the couples who get through it do.

Separate days, shared evenings. Paul Newman had his racing, Joanne had her theater. Kirk had his writing, Anne had her charities. Every long couple in this book had a life of their own by day. If you are both home, you need somewhere to be, separately, several days a week: a class, a volunteer shift, a friend, a gym, a shed. “Stay gone,” as Dolly says, a little.

A shared project. Not the television. Something that is yours together: a garden, a grandchild’s weekly visit, a charity, a trip to plan, a house to fix, a dog to walk. The Newmans had the camp. Couples with a project talk more and fight less.

Divide the house again. The kitchen, the car, the checkbook, the calendar. Forty years of roles get scrambled by retirement. Sit down, once, and decide who does what now, out loud. Many wives discover that they are furious about the drawers because nobody ever asked.

Keep writing. The Douglases wrote letters. You may write notes, or simply talk, every evening, about something other than logistics. Couples who have one real

conversation a day, about a memory, an idea, a plan, a feeling, rate their marriages far higher. Ask him what he thinks about something. Tell him what you think. It is astonishing how many couples of fifty years have stopped.

Steak at home. A compliment, a touch, a thank-you, once a day. The research is blunt: couples who last say five kind things for every critical one. Count yours for a week.

Three things to do this week

1. **Each of you picks one thing to do alone, out of the house, every week,** and puts it on the calendar.
2. **Have one conversation that is not about logistics.** Ask: “What’s something you’ve been thinking about lately?” and listen for five minutes.
3. **Write him a note.** One paragraph. Leave it where he will find it. Anne Douglas kept hers for sixty years.

Chapter 7. Glen and Kim, Tony and Susan: When your husband gets sick

In 2011, Glen Campbell was diagnosed with Alzheimer's disease. He was seventy-five. His wife Kim, who had been married to him for twenty-nine years and had seen him through alcoholism and cocaine before that, made a decision that shocked his doctors.

They would tell the world. And then he would go on tour.

The Goodbye Tour ran for more than a hundred and fifty shows over a year and a half, with his children in the band and a teleprompter he increasingly could not follow. A documentary crew filmed all of it. Audiences watched a man who could not remember the name of the town he was in play "Wichita Lineman" perfectly, because music lives in a different part of the brain than names. Kim was at every show. When he wandered, she steered. When he got angry, which Alzheimer's patients do, she absorbed it. When he forgot who she was, she introduced herself.

In 2014, when she could no longer keep him safe at home, she moved him into a memory care facility, and the

tabloids called her cruel. She has written about that decision since, in a memoir, and about what it cost her: her health, her sleep, her friendships, the years when she disappeared into his illness. She started a foundation for caregivers. Her message to the wives who write to her is always the same: “You cannot pour from an empty cup. Get help before you break.”

Glen died in 2017. Kim says she does not regret a single show.

Tony Bennett’s wife Susan did it differently, and just as well. Tony was diagnosed with Alzheimer’s in 2016, at ninety. Susan, forty years younger, kept it private for five years, kept him singing, kept him walking in Central Park every day, and, with his doctors’ blessing, let him record and perform with Lady Gaga almost to the end, because singing was the one thing the disease left untouched. His last concerts, at ninety-five, at Radio City Music Hall, were by every account joyful. He died in 2023. She has said the hardest part was not the caring. It was watching the world decide he was gone while he was still there, still singing.

What this means for you

Half of the married women reading this book will, at some point, care for a sick husband. Most men over seventy will need care before they die, and most of that care is given by a wife, at home, unpaid, for years. This is the chapter about surviving it.

Caregiving is a health risk to you. Spouses who care for a partner with dementia have higher rates of depression, heart disease, and death than people their age who do not. Kim Campbell nearly broke. The single most important thing you can do for your husband is to stay well enough to care for him, which means the next five points are not selfish.

Get help early, before you are desperate. Your Area Agency on Aging, found through the Eldercare Locator at 1-800-677-1116, can tell you what exists near you: adult day programs, respite care so you can sleep, home aides, meal delivery, transportation, support groups. Medicare does not pay for long-term custodial care at home, which shocks most families; Medicaid may, depending on income, and some veterans' benefits do. Ask early.

Join a support group. Not optional. The Alzheimer's Association runs them everywhere, in person and by phone, and their helpline at 800-272-3900 is open twenty-four hours. Caregivers who attend a group report less depression and keep their husbands at home longer than those who try alone. Kim Campbell's foundation exists because she had no one to ask.

Keep one thing that is yours. Susan Bennett kept the walks. Kim kept the music. An hour a day, a morning a week, that is not caregiving. A friend, a class, a church, a walk. Without it, the research is clear, you will not last.

Learn the illness. Alzheimer's, Parkinson's, stroke, heart failure, cancer: each has a pattern, and knowing what is coming lets you plan rather than panic. Ask the doctor for the honest course. Ask what to expect in six months and in two years.

Decide the hard things while he can still decide with you. Who will make medical decisions, and what he wants at the end. Whether he would want to be at home or in care. The money. The will. A healthcare power of attorney

and a living will, done with a lawyer or through your state's free forms, while he can sign them. Kim Campbell has said that the one thing she would tell every wife is to have those conversations before the diagnosis, because afterward it is too late.

Placing him in care is not failure. Kim Campbell was called cruel for it. The people who called her cruel had never spent a night with a man who did not know where the bathroom was and would not let her sleep. When home is no longer safe, for him or for you, a good facility is love. Visit, sing, hold his hand, and go home and sleep.

Three things to do this week

1. **If your husband is well, have the conversation.** "If you got sick, what would you want?" Write it down. Ask about the healthcare proxy forms.
2. **If you are caring for him now, make one phone call for help:** the Eldercare Locator or the Alzheimer's helpline. Just ask what exists. You do not have to accept anything yet.

3. **Protect one hour.** This week, one hour that is yours, with someone else watching him, even a neighbor. Put it on the calendar first.

Part Three: After Loss

Chapter 8. Betty White: Widowed at 59, forty years of a full life

Betty White married Allen Ludden, the host of the game show *Password*, in 1963, after turning him down twice. She said later that the two refusals were the stupidest thing she ever did, because they cost her a year of a marriage that would only get eighteen.

In 1981, Allen died of stomach cancer. Betty was fifty-nine.

She has described the first year with the plainness she brought to everything. She did not sleep. She could not eat. She kept his clothes in the closet. She went back to work within weeks, not because she was brave but because the house was unbearable and the set was the only place where

people needed her at nine in the morning. She has said that work saved her life, and she meant it literally.

Then she did something that, in Hollywood, where everyone remarries, was almost unheard of. She never did it again. For forty years, she was asked, and for forty years she gave the same answer: “Once you’ve had the best, who needs the rest?” She was not against love. She had had it. She was done.

What she was not done with was life. The forty years after Allen’s death were, by any measure, the fullest of her career. *The Golden Girls* at sixty-three. *Hot in Cleveland* at eighty-eight. *Saturday Night Live* the same year. A dozen books. Fifty years with the Los Angeles Zoo. More friends than anyone in the business, most of them younger, because, she said, the older ones kept dying and she needed replacements. A dog, always. Crosswords, daily. A vodka, nightly. A new project, constantly.

How did she do it? When asked, in her nineties, how a widow should get through, she gave four pieces of advice, scattered over several interviews, which add up to a plan.

“Get up and get dressed, every day, even if you’re not going anywhere.”

“Say yes to everything for a year. Then you can start saying no.”

“Get an animal. It needs you at seven in the morning whether you feel like it or not.”

“Don’t talk about him in the past tense. He’s still part of your life. I still talk to Allen.”

She died in 2021, at ninety-nine. Her last word, according to the friend who was with her, was “Allen.”

What this means for you

Betty White’s instincts in 1981 match, almost point for point, what forty years of research on widowhood has since found.

The first year is the dangerous one. A widow’s risk of dying rises sharply in the months after her husband’s death. Doctors call it the widowhood effect. The causes are not mysterious: she stops eating, stops sleeping, stops

taking her medicine, stops going out, and, in some cases, suffers a real heart injury from the shock, which the next chapter covers. Betty's "get up and get dressed" is medicine.

Routine is the scaffold. Work, a pet, a standing appointment, a weekly lunch. Grief has no shape; a day with a shape holds you up. Widows who keep a daily structure, any structure, recover faster.

Say yes. Betty's rule for the first year is also what grief counselors recommend: accept the invitations even when you do not feel like it, because feeling like it comes after going, not before. Isolation deepens grief; company dilutes it, a little at a time.

You do not have to "move on." Betty talked to Allen for forty years. Modern grief research has abandoned the idea that you must let go. The healthy pattern is what researchers call continuing bonds: he stays part of your life, in conversation, in memory, in the way you make the coffee, while your life grows around the loss rather than past it.

Remarrying is one path. Not remarrying is another. About a quarter of widowed men remarry; fewer than one in ten widowed women do, partly by choice and partly by arithmetic. Neither is right. What matters is whether the life is full. Betty's was.

Grief that does not lift is something else. If, a year on, you still cannot eat, sleep, or leave the house, or if you ever feel you do not want to go on, it has become depression, which is common, treatable, and not a failure of love. Tell your doctor, or call 988.

Three things to do this week

1. **If you are widowed, get up and get dressed tomorrow,** shoes on, as if you were going somewhere. Then go somewhere, even the mailbox.
2. **Say yes to one invitation this week,** from anyone. If no one has invited you, invite someone: a neighbor, for coffee.

3. **Talk to him.** Out loud, in the kitchen, about your day. Betty did it for forty years, and she was the sanest woman in Hollywood.

Chapter 9. Dolly, 2025: “I have to keep busy”

Carl Dean died on March 3, 2025, at eighty-two. He had been ill for some time; Dolly had cancelled a run of Las Vegas shows the year before, citing family matters, and had said little. When he died, she said less: a statement thanking people for their prayers, asking for privacy. The man who had never given an interview was buried the way he had lived, quietly.

Then, within days, she released a song she had written for him, called “If You Hadn’t Been There.” And she went back to work.

That is the part that people found hard to understand. A widow of three days, back in the studio. But when she

finally spoke about it, a few weeks later, she said what every widow in America understood instantly.

“I have to keep busy. If I sat still, I don’t know what I’d do.”

And then, with the honesty that is the reason people love her: “I cry every day. I talk to him. The house is so quiet. But I’ve got to keep going, because that’s what he’d want, and because I don’t know any other way.”

She was seventy-nine. In the months that followed, she kept every commitment she could. She postponed some, and was honest about why: she said in the fall of 2025 that she had some health problems of her own to deal with, that she was not dying, and that people should stop praying so hard. She kept the Imagination Library mailing books. She turned eighty in January 2026 and said she did not plan to retire, because retirement would mean sitting still, and she had already told the world what she thought of that.

What she has not done, as far as anyone can tell, is pretend. She has not said she is fine. She has said she is working.

What this means for you: the twelve months

Dolly’s instinct is right, with one addition that she would be the first to accept: keeping busy only works if it includes eating, sleeping, taking your medicine, and letting people in. Here is the first year, in order.

The first month: your body. The shock of a spouse’s death can injure the heart. Doctors call it takotsubo cardiomyopathy, or broken heart syndrome: a surge of stress hormones stuns the heart muscle, and it feels exactly like a heart attack. It mostly happens to women over sixty, most often in the weeks after a loss, and it is usually recoverable if treated. Chest pain, pressure, or shortness of breath in the first weeks after a death is an emergency. Call 911. Do not assume it is grief.

In the same month: eat something with protein three times a day, even if you do not want it. Sleep when you can. Take your pills. Let someone sit with you.

The first three months: do not decide. Do not sell the house, move in with a child, give money away, lend money, or change your will unless you must. Grief clouds

judgment, and the first weeks bring both people who want to help and people who want to take advantage. Anyone who pressures a new widow to decide anything quickly is to be refused.

The first six months: the paperwork, slowly, with help. Death certificates, the will, Social Security survivor benefits (call 1-800-772-1213; you may be entitled to his benefit if it is higher than yours), his pension, life insurance, the bank accounts, the house title, the car. Ask a child, a friend, or a lawyer to sit with you for this. Nobody should do it alone. The Eldercare Locator at 1-800-677-1116 can point you to free legal help for seniors.

All year: the room. Find a bereavement group. Hospices run them free, for anyone in the community, not only their own families. Churches run them. Senior centers run them. Once a week, in a room with other women who have lost husbands, is the single most effective thing a widow can do for her health in the first year. You do not need to talk. You need to be in the room.

All year: keep busy, Dolly's way. Work, if you have it. Volunteer, if you don't. The Imagination Library is Dolly's; yours may be the church kitchen, the library, the grandchildren, the shelter. Purpose is not a distraction from grief. It is the thing that carries you through it.

After a year: notice. Most widows describe the second year as different from the first: the grief does not end, but it stops being the whole sky. If that has not happened, if you are still not eating, not sleeping, not going out, see your doctor. Grief that does not move has become something treatable.

Three things to do this week

1. **If you have lost someone recently, call a hospice and ask about bereavement groups open to the community.** Go once.
2. **Write down the three decisions people are pressing you to make,** and beside each one write "not before" and a date at least six months away.

3. **Keep busy at one thing that needs you tomorrow morning.** Dolly’s is books. Choose yours.

Part Four: Friends and Family

Chapter 10. The Golden Girls: They did not all like each other

For seven years, from 1985 to 1992, four women over fifty shared a house in Miami on Saturday nights, and America decided that this was what friendship in later life looked like: cheesecake at midnight, every secret told, every fight forgiven by the end of the episode.

The truth behind the fame was more complicated, and more useful.

Betty White and Bea Arthur did not get along. Bea found Betty's relentless cheerfulness exhausting and said so; Betty found Bea's moods hard to be around and said that too, though more gently. Rue McClanahan and Betty were close. Estelle Getty, who played the oldest of the four, was

in fact the youngest and was terrified every week that she would forget her lines, which she sometimes did, and the others covered for her. They were colleagues who became something like family, with everything that word implies: loyalty, irritation, and showing up.

What they actually had, which the show made look easy, was the thing that research on aging keeps finding to be the single strongest predictor of a long and happy life. Not diet. Not exercise. Not money. People. Close relationships that you can count on.

The longest study of adult life ever done, run at Harvard since 1938, has followed hundreds of people from their twenties into their nineties, and its director summed up eighty years of findings in one sentence: “Loneliness kills. It’s as powerful as smoking or alcoholism.” The people who were happiest and healthiest at eighty were not the richest or the most successful. They were the ones who, at fifty, had the warmest relationships.

And here is the hard part. By seventy, most women have lost a large share of the friends they had at fifty. Husbands

die. Friends die, or move to be near children, or stop driving, or slide into illness. The circle shrinks, and the shrinking is so gradual that nobody notices until the phone stops ringing. One in three Americans over sixty-five now lives alone. Nearly half say they are lonely.

Betty White's solution was practical and a little ruthless. "I keep making younger friends," she said, "because the older ones keep dying." Rita Moreno has a circle of women she has known for fifty years and calls them every week. Jane Fonda and Lily Tomlin, after forty years, talk nearly every day. Carol Burnett has a standing lunch. The stars who stayed well into their nineties all describe the same thing: friendship was not something that happened to them. It was something they did.

What this means for you: how to make a friend at 70

It feels impossible. It is not. The recipe is the same at every age, and it is almost embarrassingly simple.

Show up at the same place, at the same time, every week. Friendship is built on repetition, not chemistry. Researchers estimate it takes about fifty hours of shared time to turn an acquaintance into a casual friend, and about two hundred to make a close one. A weekly class, a volunteer shift, a church group, a walking group, a library book club, a senior center lunch. Three months of Tuesdays makes a friend.

Talk to the same people. Sit in the same seat. Learn their names. Ask one question about their lives and remember the answer for next week. That is the entire technique, and most people never do it.

Say the first invitation out loud. “Would you like to get coffee after?” The other person is almost always waiting for someone else to say it. Older adults consistently report that they would like more friends and assume nobody else does.

Mix the ages. Betty White’s younger friends kept her current, kept her laughing, and, bluntly, outlived her. A friend who is forty will be there when you are eighty.

Grandchildren’s friends’ parents, younger neighbors, the people in the class, the woman at the library desk.

Keep the old ones on a schedule. A standing weekly call with each of the two or three oldest friends you have left. Put it on the calendar like a doctor’s appointment. Rita Moreno’s circle did not keep itself.

Do not wait for the perfect friend. The Golden Girls did not all like each other. They showed up anyway, for seven years, and became family. Friendship after sixty-five is less about finding your soulmate and more about finding your Tuesday people.

Where to go, this month:

- Your senior center, which is no longer what it was: art, tai chi, computers, trips, lunch for a dollar. Find it through the Eldercare Locator, 1-800-677-1116.
- Your public library: book clubs, classes, film afternoons, conversation groups.
- A church, synagogue or temple, even if you have drifted. They are the oldest friendship machines there

are.

- AmeriCorps Seniors, which places volunteers over fifty-five in schools and hospitals, with other volunteers.
- Any class at a community college, many free for residents over sixty.
- A walking group, a water aerobics class, a choir. Singing with other people is, in several studies, the single fastest way adults form bonds.

Three things to do this week

1. **Choose your Tuesday.** One weekly thing, at a fixed time, with the same people, and go for twelve weeks before you judge it.
2. **Make the first invitation.** To anyone you have spoken to more than twice. Coffee. After.
3. **Schedule the old friends.** Pick two, call each one, and set a standing time to talk every week. Write it on the calendar.

Chapter 11. Goldie, Dolly, Carol: The grandmother they call

Goldie Hawn’s grandchildren do not call her Grandma. They call her GoGo, and it suits her: she is the one who dances, who gets on the floor, who turns up with ridiculous presents and stays for a week. Kate Hudson, her daughter, has said that her children’s favorite days are GoGo days.

Dolly Parton has no children of her own, but she has been “Aunt Granny” to dozens of nieces, nephews and their children for sixty years, and she has sent a free book every month to more than two hundred million other people’s children through her Imagination Library. She has said that being Aunt Granny, present and spoiling and available, has been one of the great joys of a life without children, and that she does not regret the trade.

Carol Burnett, at eighty-seven, became her grandson’s legal guardian. Her daughter Erin was in the grip of addiction; the boy, Dylan, needed a home; Carol and her husband Brian went to court and got him. A woman who had buried one daughter, at an age when most people are

being cared for themselves, took on a teenager. She has said it was not a sacrifice. It was simply what grandmothers do.

Three very different grandmothers, and one thing in common that research on grandparenting keeps finding: the grandmother who is *present*, in whatever way her life allows, is one of the strongest protective factors in a child's life, and the relationship protects her just as much. Older adults who are close to grandchildren have lower rates of depression and, in several studies, better memory and longer lives. The one caution, which Carol Burnett's story shows, is that it can also become a burden heavy enough to break you, and that the grandmother who carries everything is the one who ends up alone and ill.

What this means for you

Here are the four problems that grandmothers over sixty-five bring to counselors most often, and what helps.

Distance. Your grandchildren are three states away and you see them twice a year. Goldie Hawn's answer is to make the visits enormous: when she is there, she is entirely

there, phone off, on the floor. Between visits, the research is encouraging: regular video calls, even short ones, build real bonds with children as young as two, and a weekly five-minute call that is *yours*, at a fixed time, matters more than a long monthly one. Read them a book over the phone. Ask a grandchild to teach you something on the screen. Send real mail; children under ten treasure a letter with their name on it. And if the phone frightens you, ask the grandchild to set it up. They would love to.

Money. Grandmothers are, statistically, the family bank: college funds, car repairs, rent, and the emergencies of adult children. A great deal of it is love and some of it is being used. The rule from financial counselors is simple: never give what you cannot afford to lose, never lend what you cannot afford to give, and never, ever sign a loan, a lease, or a credit card for an adult child or grandchild without a lawyer looking at it. Your retirement is not refundable. A grandmother who gives away her security ends up needing the children she gave it to.

Boundaries with adult children. The grandmother who is always available becomes free child care, and resentment

grows on both sides. Say what you can do and what you cannot, out loud, early: “I can take them Tuesdays and Thursdays. I cannot do weekends.” Dolly’s Aunt Granny gives presents and parties, not full-time care, and everyone knows it. Clear limits make the time you do give a gift rather than an obligation.

Raising them. More than two million American grandparents are raising grandchildren, most because of addiction, illness, prison or death in the middle generation. If this is you, Carol Burnett’s story has two lessons. First, make it legal: guardianship or custody, through the court, so that you can enroll the child in school, consent to medical care, and be protected if the parent reappears. Legal aid for seniors is free in most states; the Eldercare Locator at 1-800-677-1116 will find it. Second, get help. There are state programs that pay a monthly stipend to relatives raising children, called kinship or child-only grants, and almost nobody applies for them because nobody tells them they exist. Generations United and your state’s GrandFacts sheet list every program. And find other grandparents in the same boat; the support groups exist and they are a lifeline.

And the joy. GoGo days. Reading over the phone. A letter in the mailbox. Being the one person in a child's life who is never in a hurry, never disappointed, always glad to see them. It is, by every measure, one of the best things that can happen to a woman after sixty-five, and it is available to grandmothers, great-aunts, godmothers, and the neighbor who became Nana. Dolly Parton has no children. She is the most famous grandmother in America.

Three things to do this week

1. **Set the call.** One fixed time each week, five to ten minutes, that belongs to you and one grandchild. Ask them to set up the screen.
2. **Send a letter.** With their name on the envelope. A joke, a memory of their parent at that age, a stamp.
3. **Say one limit out loud** to an adult child, kindly, this week: what you can do, and what you cannot. Then see how much lighter the "can" feels.

Part Five: Yourself

Chapter 12. Diane Keaton: Never married, never lonely

Diane Keaton never married.

She had, by her own cheerful account, three of the most famous boyfriends of the twentieth century, Woody Allen, Warren Beatty and Al Pacino, and she declined, or was never asked, or let it pass, to marry any of them. At fifty she adopted a daughter. At fifty-five she adopted a son. She raised them alone, in a house she had restored herself, with her dog, her books, her hats, her cameras and her architecture obsessions, and when reporters asked her, every few years for forty years, whether she regretted never finding a husband, she laughed and said no.

“I don’t think I was built for it,” she said once. And: “I’m an odd duck. I like my life.”

She was not a hermit. She had a vast circle of friends, many of them former loves; she and Woody Allen remained close for fifty years. She worked constantly, into her late seventies. She wrote books about her mother, her houses, her hats. She was, by the account of everyone who knew her, one of the funniest and most engaged people in Hollywood, and one of the least lonely.

She died in October 2025, at seventy-nine, and the tributes that poured out, from men who had loved her and women who had wanted to be her, said the same thing in different ways: she had built a life that was entirely her own, and it had been full.

This chapter is for the women who, after reading eleven chapters about love, have decided, or always knew, that they are not looking for anyone. The widow who, like Betty White, has had the best. The divorcee who, like Jane Fonda, does not want to take care of anybody. The woman who, like Diane Keaton, was never built for it. You are not the exception in this book. You are a third of the women reading it, and you deserve a plan as good as anyone else’s.

What this means for you: a full life on its own

The research is clear that loneliness is dangerous, and equally clear that being alone is not the same thing. People who live alone by choice, with a full life, are as healthy and happy as married people. What matters is not whether someone else is in the house. It is whether the days have shape, the week has people, and the life has purpose. Here is how the stars who lived alone built that.

A house that is yours. Keaton restored houses for the pleasure of it. Betty White kept Allen’s chair. Doris Day filled hers with dogs. A woman alone should live somewhere she loves, arranged exactly as she likes, with no concessions. It is one of the real luxuries of being single, and one that married women envy.

Days with a shape. Up at a fixed hour, dressed, shoes on. Breakfast at the table. Something that must be done in the morning: work, a dog, a garden, a volunteer shift, a class. Something social in the week, on a schedule. Dinner at the table, not the sofa. Bed at a fixed hour. The shape is what keeps the day from dissolving.

A creature. Keaton had dogs. Betty White had dogs. Doris Day had, at times, thirty. A pet is company, a reason to get up, a reason to walk, and a reason to talk to strangers; dog owners over sixty-five have more conversations in a week than almost anyone. A cat will do. So will a bird.

Work, or its equivalent. Keaton acted into her late seventies. Betty White worked until ninety-eight. If you are retired, “work” means the thing that needs you: the library desk, the church kitchen, the hospital gift shop, the grandchild, the garden. Something that has your name on a schedule.

Your people, on purpose. Chapter 10’s Tuesday people. The standing calls. Keaton’s enormous circle was built the same way everyone’s is: by showing up, for fifty years.

Something you are learning. Keaton learned architecture, photography, publishing, in her sixties and seventies. A mind with a project does not have room to be lonely. A language, an instrument, a craft, a history, a course at the community college.

Travel, alone, if you can. Older women are now the fastest-growing group of solo travelers in America, and tour companies have noticed: there are group trips built for women over sixty traveling alone, where the “alone” lasts until the first dinner.

Dress for yourself. Keaton’s hats, her gloves, her turtlenecks in July, were not for anyone else. A woman alone who gets dressed every morning for her own pleasure is, the research says, less depressed, more active, and more likely to leave the house. Also, she looks wonderful.

And love, in all its other forms. Keaton’s fifty-year friendship with a man she once loved. Betty’s forty-year conversation with a husband who was gone. Dolly’s two hundred million children. Carol’s grandson. Love after sixty-five is not only romance, and a life without a partner is not a life without love. It is, often, a life with more of it, spread wider.

Three things to do this week

1. **Change one thing in your house** so that it is exactly as you want it, with no one else’s opinion. Move the chair. Paint the door. Hang the picture.
2. **Give your day a shape** for seven days: up, dressed, breakfast at the table, one thing that must be done by noon, one person spoken to, dinner at the table, bed on time.
3. **Start learning something** this week that you have always wanted to know. One lesson, one book, one video. Diane Keaton took up photography at an age when most people put the camera down.

At the Back of the Book

The safe-dating checklist

Keep this by the telephone or in your purse.

- I talk on the phone before I meet. Twenty minutes tells me more than three dinners.
- I meet in public, in daylight, for coffee, for an hour, with my own transportation.
- I tell a friend or family member where I am going and who I am meeting.
- I never send money, gift cards, wire transfers or bank details to anyone I have not met in person many times, whatever the story.
- I am suspicious of anyone who says they love me within days, who cannot meet in person or on video, who is “overseas,” or who asks me to keep our relationship secret from my family.

- I do not lend money, co-sign anything, add anyone to my accounts, or change my will for anyone I have known less than a year, and never without a lawyer.
- I say the true things early: my health, my children, my late husband, my money.
- If something feels wrong, it is. I can call the AARP Fraud Watch helpline at 877-908-3360 and ask.
- I can say no, at any point, for any reason, without explaining.

The questions to settle before a late marriage

Dick Van Dyke, Joan Collins and Carol Burnett all married late and well. Every one of them had lawyers. Before you marry or move in with someone after sixty-five, settle these, out loud, with each other, and with a lawyer:

1. **Money.** What is yours, what is his, what becomes shared. Most couples who marry late keep their finances separate. A prenuptial agreement is not an insult; it protects both of you and both of your families.

2. **The house.** Whose name is on it, who lives there if one of you dies, and whether the other can stay.
3. **Children and inheritance.** What each of you intends to leave to your own children. Say it now, in writing, so that no one fights at a funeral.
4. **Health care.** Who makes medical decisions for each of you: the new spouse, a child, or both. Update your healthcare power of attorney and living will.
5. **Care.** If one of you becomes ill, what happens. Who will care for whom, with what help, and where. Have this conversation while you are both well.
6. **Benefits.** Marriage can change Social Security survivor benefits, pensions, veterans' benefits and Medicaid eligibility. Call Social Security at 1-800-772-1213 and ask before you set a date; some widows lose a late husband's benefit by remarrying before sixty.
7. **The will.** Both of you update it, with a lawyer, the month you marry.

The 30-day connection plan

One small step a day. Miss a day and start again the next.

Week 1: Reach out. Day 1: call the oldest friend you have. Day 2: write a letter to a grandchild. Day 3: invite a neighbor for coffee. Day 4: find your senior center's calendar. Day 5: say yes to one invitation. Day 6: set a weekly call with one person. Day 7: rest, and notice who called you back.

Week 2: Show up. Day 8: choose your Tuesday thing and go. Day 9: get dressed, shoes on, and go somewhere, anywhere. Day 10: talk to one stranger. Day 11: schedule the grandchild video call. Day 12: go to your Tuesday thing again. Day 13: tell one family member how you really feel about company. Day 14: rest.

Week 3: Deepen. Day 15: ask someone one real question and remember the answer. Day 16: make the first invitation: coffee, after. Day 17: write the two lists, must-have and never-again. Day 18: Tuesday thing. Day 19: do one thing for your own life. Day 20: revive one ritual, with a spouse or a friend. Day 21: rest.

Week 4: Decide. Day 22: answer the question on paper: do I want someone in my life? Day 23: if yes, tell one friend. If no, change one thing in your house to suit yourself. Day 24: learn something new, one lesson. Day 25: Tuesday thing. Day 26: write a note to someone you love and leave it where they will find it. Day 27: if you are grieving, find the room: call a hospice about a group. Day 28: rest.

Days 29 and 30. Look at the calendar. Count the people you spoke to this month. Next month, make it one more.

Numbers to keep by the phone

- **988** Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, call or text, any hour, for yourself or someone you love.
- **1-800-677-1116** Eldercare Locator: senior centers, classes, caregiver help, legal aid, your Area Agency on Aging.
- **877-908-3360** AARP Fraud Watch helpline, free, for any call, letter, email or romance that feels wrong.

- **800-272-3900** Alzheimer’s Association, 24 hours, for caregivers.
- **1-800-772-1213** Social Security, for survivor benefits and questions before remarriage.
- **1-800-799-7233** National Domestic Violence Hotline. Abuse happens after sixty-five too, and help is confidential.

A last word

Dick Van Dyke is dancing in the kitchen with Arlene. Joan Collins is on a terrace in the south of France with Percy. Carol Burnett is at lunch with Brian and a grandson who is now a young man. Betty White is talking to Allen. Dolly is at the studio, keeping busy. Goldie is on the floor with the grandchildren. Diane Keaton is in a house she restored herself, in a hat, laughing.

Every one of them, after sixty-five, made a choice about love. Some chose a person. Some chose their friends. Some chose their work, their grandchildren, their dogs, themselves. None of them chose to wait.

If this book helped you, tell us which chapter in the comments of any of our videos. And if there is a love story behind the fame that you would like us to open the files on, tell us that too.

Keep showing up. Keep saying yes. Keep loving, in whatever form it takes.

The Behind the Fame team